

Freecom Tough Drive Pink 250 GB

Gigabits On A Pink Platter

Freecom, though unknown to the Indian market is an established player in the external storage arena. In the past, we have reviewed Freecom drives and now that Freecom has officially come to India, we expect them to be priced sanely.

The Tough Drive series, as the name suggests, is aimed at enduring shock. This particular drive is clad in pink rubber, which Freecom hopes will lure the fairer sex.

Thankfully, the Tough Drives are available in other colour options. In terms of design, the drive is sleek but not portable, obviously due to the thick layer of rubber cladding it dons. The rubberised body feels good to hold, but the tyre pattern design on it

doesn't do anything to enhance its looks.

On the brighter side, the Tough drives are indeed solidly put together and sport good design from the usability aspect. Apart from the rubber cladding, internally the hard drives are put on a spring suspended frame (anti-shock frame) for better shock absorption. The USB connector is integrated in the drives, and hence there is no need to carry along any cables. The drive can be directly connected to the PC. The USB connector lights up blue, and blinks during data transfer. The Tough drive doesn't require additional power and runs off a single USB port.

Freecom has bundled back-up software, namely NTI shadow. It can do real time continuous data



backup, scheduled back-up and has version control. Thus older files can be retrieved. The user interface is simple and the settings are granular to the point that you can even select the types of files to be backed up.

Internally, the Tough Drive comes with 5,400 RPM Fujitsu hard drive and delivers good performance. 4 GB (1 DVD) of assorted data takes less than 3 min to copy whereas a 1 GB (one movie)

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

took around 39 sec to copy. We say the drive is fast for most purposes it will be used for.

Priced at Rs 10,150, the Tough drive is a reasonable buy. Ordinary 250 GB drives are available in the Rs 8,500 region and the small premium of Rs 1,500 for shock proofing is well worth it in the longer run. However, we would prefer to never see the pick version again—black or blue please!

Specifications

5,400 RPM drive, 2 m drop shock proof, USB 2.0 and Integrated USB connector

Contact: Rashi peripherals Pvt Ltd.
Phone: +91-22-67090909
E-mail: freecom@rptechindia.com
Web site: www.freecom.com
Price: Rs 10,150

SanDisk Sansa View

A Sleek Vision

The View is SanDisk's attempt at a video oriented PMP and features a slightly larger screen than their mainstream E200 series. It's also a slightly longer device, and gives up the metal back for a matt finished black rear that adds a touch of class to an already up-market looking device. The ribbed click wheel also goes in favour of a smooth finish with a smooth moving click wheel. The menu system remains the same, but we found exploration a little better, courtesy the new smooth action wheel. Expansion is via MicroSD now. Should for some reason 16 GB onboard be insufficient, and given the fact that 8 GB MicroSD cards are slowly making their way to the market space, is never going to be a constraint.



All the features we loved on the E200 series are present—FM radio, voice recording, video and image

viewing—although features like an alarm clock, calendar, and the ability to store notes was absent—a pity SanDisk didn't think of adding anything new. Navigating the menu is simple and the same ease of use has been carried over to the FM radio too. Setting up the channels took very little time. The screen is also a touch below par, especially when compared to the screen on the new Apple iPod Nano 3G, its logical competitor. Other devices like Cowon's D2 and Apple's Touch are miles ahead. Music quality is the other significant parameter, and the View doesn't disappoint here. Although we noticed good volume levels, the View isn't as loud as either the

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★★
Build Quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
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D2 or the Nano / Touch duo, nor is it as defined in the highs. In fact, bass doesn't extend as low as the competition, and while it does pound lightly, it's not the thump that we've seen from the best of the PMPs in our tests.

At Rs 12,790, the Sansa View is a good and reasonably feature-rich PMP. The problem is that it doesn't stand out at anything, preferring mediocrity to fame. It's hard to recommend to anyone, with each of the competition mentioned above doing at least something better, while retaining all the same features.

Specifications

16 GB Flash, MicroSD expandable, 2.4-inch LCD, FM radio, Voice recording, H.264 video playback

Contact: Rashi Peripherals Pvt Ltd
Phone: +91-22-67090909
E-mail: sandisk@rptechindia.com
Web site: www.rptechindia.com
Price: Rs 12,790

Dell XPS 420

The Good 420



The XPS 420 is the top of the line Dell desktop model for the Indian market. Cramped with features, the XPS 420 is a multimedia powerhouse aimed at gamers, enthusiasts, etc

This new model features a new completely revised chassis. Finished in shiny black plastic, the front panel is a smudge magnet and attracts much dust as well. The side panels finished in brushed aluminium with a big XPS logo scream for attention. One unique thing about the XPS 420 is the presence of small LCD screen on the top (Windows Sideshow) an extension of Vista's Sidebar. This small LCD can be used for showing small tidbits of information via the sidebar gadgets. New gadgets can be downloaded from Microsoft's Web site.

The base configuration consists of Intel Quad core Q6600, 2 GB of DDR II 667 MHz, 250 GB hard drive and 8600 GTS graphics card. These components are powerful enough to ensure a high-end rig experience, though we think the 8600 GTS is aging and expect dell to replace it soon with the newer 9600GT card.

The 20-inch LCD monitor comes bundled with the system is breathtaking. The screen is glossy and reproduces

crisp images. Movies are fun on this monitor, so is editing photographs and the sheer space on offer will allow you to open two word pages side by side. The LCD also has an embedded 2 MP Web camera, which can be used for chatting, taking photographs and capturing video. The capture quality is good and colours are faithfully reproduced.

There is also an MPEG 2 transcoder with front mounted AV ports, which can be used for importing video from camcorders and encoding it to DivX. The accompanying software, however, isn't user friendly and requires lot of patience to learn. Additionally, there is the 19-in-one memory card reader with Bluetooth 2.0 module, wireless (Bluetooth) keyboard and mouse and a Hauppauge TV tuner card with remote. Miscellaneous items include micro fibre cloth for wiping the LCD,

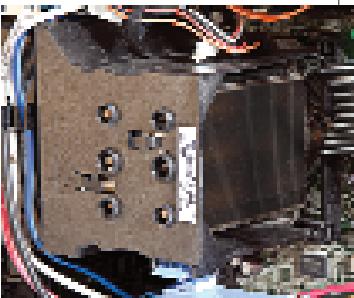


soft and hard mouse pads and a folder with the necessary manual and CDs all perfectly packed in the box.

The cabinet can be opened without any tools. All it requires is pulling a single latch to release the side panel. On the inside, everything is neatly packed. Since Dell has opted for the BTX form factor, the system requires just one fan to cool itself. The cables and wiring are tied down and routed optimally without affecting the air flow. The single 120-mm fan is placed right after the huge CPU cooler and throws out hot air from the front of the cabinet. Throughout our testing process the system remained cool and quiet. Though the cabinet is tall and the internals are neatly organised, there isn't much space for future upgrade; just two hard drive slots that's what you get here.

On the software front, Dell has bundled in Adobe's Elements Studio package consisting of the Lite version of Photoshop Elements, Premier Elements and SoundBooth

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



CS3. The typical Dell in-house software is present and they provide complete control over every aspect of this beautiful machine.

The XPS 420 performs admirably in all aspects, thanks largely to the powerful hardware that's under the hood. The Q6600 simply chewed through the test we put it through and has enough grunt to transcode home videos on the fly. Though the 8600 GTS ran through the entire graphics test delivering playable frame rate, we think it's best to upgrade to a higher card. Dell offers 8800GT in lieu of the 8600GTS and if your pocket permits you should upgrade for better gaming experience. Overall, the system performance is more than satisfactory, despite Vista running on the system, it was responsive with hardly any lag.

Priced at Rs 69,169, we feel the XPS 420 is overpriced considering the weak graphics subsystem. However, it is very difficult to recreate the overall look and feel that the XPS 420 has—the beautiful case, neatly packed interiors, stupendous hardware and the tiny LCD screen on the cabinet! If you have money to blow and appreciate style, then the XPS 420 fits the bill.

Specifications

Intel Core 2 Quad Q6600, 2 GB DDRII, 250 GB, Media Xcelerator, 8600 GTS, 20-inch LCD screen with 2 MP Web cam and Bluetooth keyboard and mouse.

Contact: Dell India Pvt. Ltd
Phone: 1800-425-4026
E-mail: dell_enquiries@dell.com
Web site: www.dell.co.in
Price: Rs 69,169